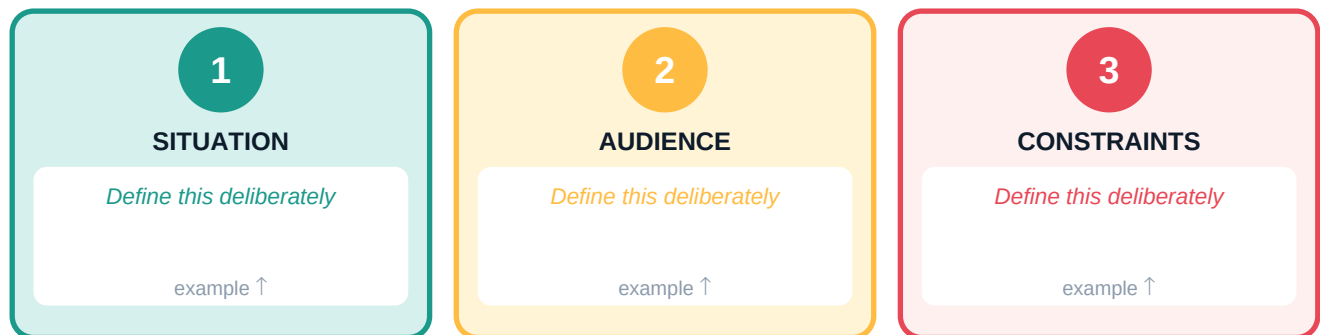


Context Is Everything



THE CONTEXT GAP Here is the practical starting point for most AI interactions: unless you provide relevant context or explicitly enable a persistence feature, AI should be treated as knowing nothing dependable about you, your work, your organisation, your history with this client, your professional constraints, or the specific situation you are dealing with.

You know all of these things. They seem obvious. So you don't mention them.

This is the context gap, the difference between what AI needs to know to give you a genuinely useful answer, and what you actually provide. It is the single most valuable gap to close.

WHAT COUNTS AS CONTEXT Context is not just background information. It is any fact about your situation that would change how a knowledgeable person would approach the task. It includes:

Situational context, What is happening? What is the history? Why does this matter now?

Audience context, Who is going to read, use, or act on this output? What do they know? What do they need? What are their constraints?

Relationship context, What is the relationship between parties? Long-standing client? New contact? Internal colleague? Adversarial negotiation?

Constraint context, What must the output not include? What word count, format, or style requirements apply? What legal, regulatory, or policy constraints apply?

Resource context, What documents, data, or previous work is relevant? What has already been tried?

Goal context, What does success look like? What decision will this output inform? What action will it prompt?

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE David runs a small consulting firm. He is writing a proposal for a client renewal and asks AI to help draft the pricing section.

Without context: AI produces a generic template for presenting consulting fees, day rates, retainer structures, and payment terms that could apply to any consulting firm anywhere.

With context: David tells AI that this client has been with the firm for four years, has three times mentioned "feeling nickel-and-dimed" by itemised billing, is a family business where the owner and CFO are the same person, and that David wants to move to a monthly retainer to create predictable revenue on both sides. He also notes the client's previous annual spend was around £42,000.

The output AI produces with this context is a specifically targeted pricing section that addresses the client's stated frustration, proposes a retainer at a price point consistent with their history, and frames the retainer in terms of what the client gets (predictability, priority access, no surprises) rather than what David gets. It is a usable draft. The generic version was not.

The difference was entirely in the context David provided.

THE CONTEXT TEST A useful diagnostic: before sending a prompt, ask yourself:



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"If I had just hired a very good human assistant who was new to this job, what would they need to know before I asked them to do this?"

That question surfaces most of the context you are probably omitting. A good assistant would ask about the audience, the history, the constraints, the goal, and the format before starting work. Providing that context in your prompt removes the need for them to ask, and removes the iterations required when AI guesses wrong.



THE BEFORE -> BETTER -> BEST: CONTEXT BEFORE

"Write an email to our supplier about a late delivery."

Output: A generic, somewhat formal complaint email about a late delivery with placeholder information. Polite but weightless.

BETTER

"Write an email to our supplier, BuildRight Ltd, about a delivery that is now 12 days late. The order was for 500 units of packaging material needed for a Christmas promotional campaign. The delay means we cannot start production on time and we risk missing the campaign window."

Output: A specific email that references the order type, the operational impact, and the time pressure. Usable with minor edits.

BEST

"Write an email to BuildRight Ltd, our packaging supplier of five years. Our contact is James Thornton in their sales team. The delivery of 500 units of promotional packaging

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(order number BRTX-2241) is now 12 days late. This delivery was critical for our Christmas campaign, production was due to start on Monday and we have an external print deadline of 18th November.

We do not want to damage the relationship, which has been excellent until this point. The tone should be: firm and clear about the business impact, but not accusatory. We want two things: a confirmed delivery date in writing and an explanation of what happened.

Do not threaten to cancel the order or use legal language at this stage."

Output: An email that reflects the history of the relationship, is specific about the business impact and timeline, makes two clear requests, and observes the explicit constraint about not escalating. Might be sent with no editing.



WHAT CHANGED?



CONTEXT ADDED WHY IT MATTERED

Five-year relationship Shaped the non-accusatory tone

Named contact Made the email personal

Order number Made the reference specific and professional

Production deadline Explained why timing matters so much

Print deadline date Created concrete urgency without exaggeration

Two specific requests Focused the email on clear outcomes

Explicit constraint (no legal Prevented escalation AI might otherwise language) include



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PROVIDING CONSTRAINT CONTEXT Constraints are particularly easy to omit because they feel obvious to you. "Obviously I can't mention the legal proceedings." "Obviously I shouldn't mention the budget number." "Obviously the tone needs to be formal."

These are obvious to you. They are invisible to AI. State every constraint that would make the output unusable if violated.

Useful constraint phrasing:

"Do not include [X]." "This cannot mention [X] for legal reasons." "The tone must not suggest [X], this would damage the relationship." "UK spelling and law applies throughout." "This will be reviewed by [X] so should not contain [Y]."

PRO TIP FOR RECURRING TASKS WHERE THE CONTEXT IS ALWAYS THE SAME, YOU DON'T NEED TO RETYPE IT EVERY TIME.

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WATCH OUT PROVIDING IRRELEVANT CONTEXT CAN DILUTE THE OUTPUT AS MUCH AS PROVIDING TOO LITTLE. IF YOU PAST

"I'm attaching our full company handbook, but for this task only the redundancy policy section (pages 14-17) is relevant."



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